

Drugs for pain relief

Various types of medication are available for pain relief during labor; many can be used alongside natural forms of pain relief.

For some, natural pain relief may not be sufficient to enable them to deal with the increasing intensity of contractions, and they may choose to use medication in combination with natural techniques. In some situations, for example if labor is induced (see [Induction of labor](#)) or augmented (see [How is labor sped up with drugs?](#)), contractions may start strongly rather than build up gradually and a stronger type of pain relief may be needed.

There are several types of medical pain relief available, which fall into two groups. Analgesic drugs dull the perception of pain, while anesthesia, which may be regional or general, numbs pain totally. In regional anesthesia, also known as a nerve block, local anesthetic drugs are injected around nerves that supply a particular area. There are several types of regional nerve block: epidurals and spinal blocks numb sensation in the abdomen and are used to reduce the pain of contractions; a pudendal block numbs sensation in the vagina and perineum and may be used in a forceps delivery. Rarely, a general anesthetic is given during a cesarean.

Since all labors are different, it's not possible to have a "one size fits all" approach to pain relief. Being flexible and informed will help you feel in control. Read any literature from your doctor, go to childbirth classes, and ask questions. Try to eliminate any worries by increasing your knowledge, for example by asking if it's possible to attend a childbirth education class at the hospital that discusses the pros and cons of each type of pain relief. Keep in mind that some childbirth classes, like Lamaze and the Bradley method, can teach you breathing and relaxation techniques that may help reduce your need for pain medication during labor.

Pain relief plan

Having a birth plan ahead of time that outlines the circumstances during which you would resort to using medication for pain relief may be helpful for some women. For example, you may want to try to remain medication-free unless the pain is so intense, it interferes with your ability to hold a normal conversation, or it doubles you over in pain. Perhaps you'll seek relief if your labor drags on hours longer than you expected and you need some respite to sleep for a while to regain your strength for the upcoming pushing that you'll be doing. Whatever the case, you may feel more in control if you know ahead of time what your limits are and when you want to say yes to pain medication, rather than being overwhelmed by the situation, if you don't give it much thought beforehand.